

Memo to the Chairperson of the Senate Judiciary Committee: Strategies for Preventing Intimate Partner Violence

Intimate Partner Violence (IPV) remains a pervasive public health issue in the United States, disproportionately impacting women and marginalized communities. Nearly 1 in 4 women report experiencing severe physical violence by an intimate partner during their lifetime, and IPV contributes significantly to adverse health outcomes, including physical injuries, mental health disorders, and even death. Economic instability, substance use, and societal norms that condone aggression perpetuate this crisis, creating urgent need for innovative and evidence-based interventions to break the cycle of violence (Postmus et al., 2012).

To address IPV effectively, I propose a comprehensive strategy centered on two key components: expanding access to community-based prevention and intervention programs, and increasing economic empowerment opportunities for individuals at high risk. These measures target the root causes of IPV while offering tangible solutions that promote safety and long-term well-being for survivors and their families.

Community-based prevention and intervention programs have demonstrated measurable success in reducing IPV. For instance, initiatives like the Domestic Violence Housing First (DVHF) program prioritize survivors' immediate needs by providing stable housing, financial assistance, and wraparound support services. Studies indicate that participants in DVHF programs report significantly higher safety and stability outcomes, with reduced recurrence of IPV over time (Sullivan & Olsen, 2016). Similarly, advocacy-based counseling and coordinated community responses have proven effective in fostering resilience among survivors and holding perpetrators accountable. These programs emphasize trauma-informed care, prioritizing

survivors' autonomy and empowering them to rebuild their lives while mitigating the risk of future violence (Sullivan & Olsen, 2016).

Economic empowerment is a critical yet often overlooked factor in IPV prevention. Financial dependence on an abusive partner is one of the primary barriers preventing survivors from leaving violent relationships. Expanding access to job training, education, and microloan initiatives can provide individuals with the resources needed to achieve financial independence. Programs such as the Allstate Foundation's Moving Ahead curriculum equip survivors with essential financial literacy skills, helping them to establish economic security and reduce their vulnerability to abuse. Research shows that economic empowerment interventions not only improve survivors' quality of life but also significantly decrease the likelihood of IPV recurrence (Postmus et al., 2012).

While these strategies are promising, potential challenges must be addressed to ensure their success. Community skepticism toward intervention programs can hinder their adoption, particularly in areas where cultural norms may discourage seeking external assistance. Additionally, funding limitations pose a significant obstacle, as implementing comprehensive programs requires substantial investment in personnel, infrastructure, and resources. Economic pushback from local industries or policymakers who prioritize other initiatives may further complicate efforts to secure the necessary support (Sullivan & Olsen, 2016).

To overcome these challenges, it is essential to engage communities in the design and implementation of programs. Partnering with trusted local leaders and organizations can build trust, ensuring that interventions are culturally relevant and responsive to the unique needs of each community. Public awareness campaigns highlighting success stories and quantitative

evidence of program efficacy can also help shift public perception and garner broader support. Addressing funding barriers requires strategic reallocation of resources from punitive measures toward prevention and rehabilitation efforts. Policymakers must recognize that investing in IPV prevention yields significant long-term benefits, including reduced healthcare costs, increased workforce participation, and safer communities (Postmus et al., 2012).

Reducing intimate partner violence necessitates a multi-faceted approach that prioritizes prevention, economic empowerment, and survivor-centered support. By scaling up community-based programs and fostering economic independence for survivors, we can address both the immediate and systemic drivers of IPV. I urge the Senate Judiciary Committee to champion these initiatives, ensuring that survivors have the tools and resources they need to lead safe, fulfilling lives.

Reference

- Postmus, J. L., Plummer, S.-B., McMahon, S., Murshid, N. S., & Kim, M. S. (2012). Understanding economic abuse in the lives of survivors. *Journal of Interpersonal Violence*, 27(3), 411-430.
- Sullivan, C. M., & Olsen, L. (2016). Domestic violence housing first: Results from a statewide evaluation. *Journal of Family Violence*, 31(1), 109-117.